

LITTLE TREE FARM · NOVA SCOTIA

FREE
STARTER
GUIDE

The Canadian *Black Walnut* Orchard Starter Kit

A practical guide to planning, planting, and growing a black walnut timber orchard — from your first seedling to a legacy measured in generations.

Learn. Plant. Thrive.



BARE-ROOT SEEDLINGS · GROWN IN NOVA SCOTIA · SHIPPED ACROSS CANADA



WELCOME

How to Use This Guide



Welcome to The Canadian Black Walnut Orchard Starter Kit.

Whether you're considering planting your first acre or exploring the idea of a larger timber orchard, this guide has been written to help you make informed decisions with confidence.

You don't need a forestry degree to grow black walnut successfully. Like many worthwhile projects, success comes from understanding the fundamentals, choosing the right site, and making good management decisions over time.

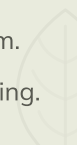
This guide is designed to be practical rather than technical. We've drawn on research from universities, forestry organizations, and experienced black walnut growers, while presenting the information in a way that is easy to understand and apply.

You can read this guide from beginning to end, or jump directly to the chapters that interest you most.



INSIDE YOU'LL LEARN

- How to determine whether black walnut is suitable for your property.
- What soil and site conditions produce the best results.
- Why we recommend planting at 14 × 14-foot spacing (approximately 222 trees per acre).
- How pruning, competition, and thinning influence timber quality.
- What to expect during the first several decades of a black walnut plantation.
- Common mistakes — and how to avoid them.
- Practical advice for planning your first planting.



Throughout the guide you'll also find practical tips, illustrations, and simple checklists to help you put these ideas into practice.

Our goal isn't to convince everyone to plant black walnut. Our goal is to help you decide whether a black walnut orchard is the right fit for your land, your goals, and your long-term vision.

If, by the end of this guide, you feel more confident about growing black walnut than when you began, then we've achieved exactly what we set out to do.

Plant with confidence — the forest starts here.





A NOTE ABOUT THIS GUIDE

The information contained in this guide is provided for general educational purposes only. Every property is unique, and tree growth is influenced by many factors including climate, soil conditions, genetics, weather, management practices, and local regulations.

While every effort has been made to provide accurate and practical information, Little Tree Farm makes no guarantee regarding tree growth, survival, timber quality, future market values, or financial returns. Readers are encouraged to evaluate their own site conditions and seek professional advice where appropriate before establishing a plantation.

References to planting methods, spacing, management practices, or equipment are intended as general recommendations and may not be suitable for every location or circumstance.

Growing trees is a long-term investment in your land, and successful outcomes depend on thoughtful planning, ongoing management, and conditions beyond anyone's control.



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Why Black Walnut?



Black walnut is one of the most interesting trees a Canadian landowner can plant.

It is a native North American hardwood known for its dark, valuable wood, strong growth, long life, and distinctive nuts. For generations, black walnut has been prized by woodworkers, sawmills, and landowners because of its rich brown heartwood and its reputation as one of the higher-value timber trees in eastern North America.

But a black walnut orchard is not a quick project.

It is not like planting an annual crop, and it is not the same as planting a few shade trees around a yard. A well-planned black walnut plantation is a long-term land project. It requires suitable soil, good weed control, early care, pruning, thinning, and patience.

For the right landowner, that is part of the appeal. A black walnut orchard can turn underused land into something productive. It can create wildlife habitat, improve the look and value of a property, produce nuts, and potentially grow high-quality timber for the next generation. Many people plant black walnut because they like the idea of doing something useful with their land — something that may outlive them.

This guide was created to help Canadian landowners understand the basics before planting. Inside, we will look at where black walnut grows best, what kind of land it needs, how many trees fit on an acre, why spacing matters, what happens during the first 10 years, and how a dense planting can gradually be thinned into a smaller number of high-quality crop trees.



THE SYSTEM DESCRIBED IN THIS GUIDE IS SIMPLE

Plant black walnut seedlings at **14 × 14 feet**, or about **222 trees per acre**. Over time, the weaker, poorer-formed, or poorly placed trees are removed. After several decades, the goal is to keep approximately **43 final crop trees per acre**, spaced roughly **32 × 32 feet** apart.

The purpose of planting more trees at the beginning is not to keep every tree forever. It is to create competition, encourage straighter stems, allow selection, and improve the odds of producing valuable timber trees.

14 × 14 ft

PLANTING SPACING

≈ 222

TREES PER ACRE

≈ 43

FINAL CROP TREES

32 × 32 ft

FINAL SPACING

Black walnut rewards good planning. The best results usually come from planting the right site, using healthy seedlings, keeping grass and weeds under control, protecting young trees from damage, pruning carefully, and thinning at the right times. Poor sites and neglect can lead to slow growth, crooked stems, low survival, and disappointing timber quality.

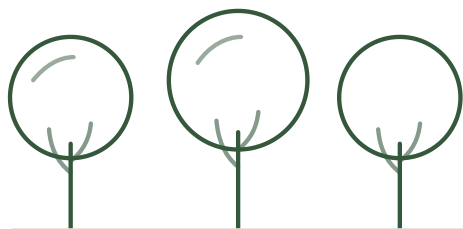
This guide does not promise easy money or guaranteed returns. Timber values vary, trees grow differently from site to site, and markets change over time. But it does show how black walnut can be approached as a practical, long-term timber orchard project.

If you own land and are wondering whether black walnut trees belong on your property, this starter kit will help you make a better decision.

YEAR 0



YEAR 40+



Many trees are planted. Only the best remain.

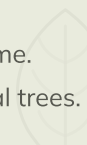


THINK LONG-TERM

A black walnut orchard is not planted for next year. It is planted for the next generation.

The trees you plant today may provide shade, wildlife habitat, nuts, and beautiful timber for decades to come.

Good management throughout the life of the plantation has a significant influence on the quality of the final trees.





Can Black Walnut Grow in Canada?



The short answer is **yes** — but not everywhere.

Black walnut (*Juglans nigra*) is native to parts of **southern Ontario** and naturally grows throughout much of the eastern United States. Although black walnut's natural Canadian range is concentrated in southern Ontario, it has been successfully planted well beyond its native distribution. With suitable soils, good drainage, and a favourable climate, black walnut has been grown successfully in many parts of southern Canada, including Quebec, the Maritime provinces, Manitoba, and parts of British Columbia. As with any tree species, local site conditions are often more important than provincial boundaries.

Like any tree species, success depends less on provincial boundaries and more on choosing the right site. A warm, well-drained field with deep, fertile soil will usually outperform a cold, wet location only a few kilometres away. Taking the time to evaluate your property before planting is one of the most important steps in establishing a successful black walnut orchard.

— Climate

Black walnut grows best in areas with:

- ☞ Warm summers
- ☞ A reasonably long growing season
- ☞ Adequate annual rainfall or supplemental watering during establishment
- ☞ Protection from severe late spring frosts where possible

Young trees are surprisingly resilient once established, but late frosts can occasionally damage new spring growth. Fortunately, healthy trees typically produce another flush of leaves later in the season.

Because black walnut is a long-lived species, it is also worth considering how your property's climate may change over the coming decades. In many parts of Canada, growing conditions for black walnut are expected to become more favourable as average temperatures gradually increase.

— Hardiness

Many people assume black walnut is only suitable for the warmest parts of Canada. In reality, healthy trees are successfully growing across a much wider area than many people realize. Cold winter temperatures are only one part of the equation. Equally important are:

- ☞ Length of the growing season
- ☞ Number of frost-free days
- ☞ Soil moisture
- ☞ Drainage
- ☞ Overall site quality



A sheltered location with excellent soil will often outperform an exposed site in the same hardiness zone.

Rather than asking, "What zone am I in?" – a better question is: "Does my property provide the conditions black walnut prefers?"

— Where Black Walnut Performs Best

In general, the most successful plantings are found on:

- Deep loam soils
- Fertile former farmland
- Well-drained river terraces
- Gentle slopes with good air drainage
- Open sites receiving full sunlight

Many former hay fields and pasturelands make excellent candidates for black walnut plantations after proper site preparation.

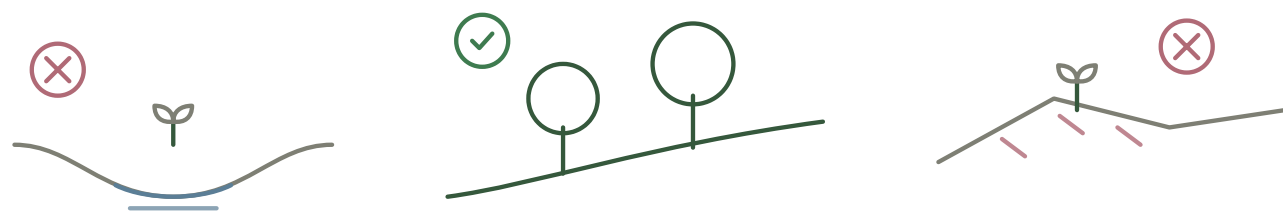
— Sites to Avoid

Some properties are simply better suited to other tree species. Black walnut generally struggles on:

- Permanently wet soils
- Heavy clay that remains waterlogged
- Shallow soils over bedrock
- Very dry, drought-prone sands
- Areas with standing water during spring
- Deep shade beneath existing forests

Poor drainage is one of the most common reasons young walnut trees fail. If your boots sink into mud every spring, black walnut is probably not the best choice for that location.

SITE SELECTION AT A GLANCE	
GOOD SITES	POOR SITES
Deep loam	Waterlogged clay
Full sun	Forest shade
Well-drained farmland	Standing water
Gentle slopes	Shallow rocky soils
Fertile fields	Very dry sand



DEPRESSION — POOR GROWTH GENTLE SLOPE — EXCELLENT GROWTH SHALLOW RIDGE — SLOWER GROWTH

Site shape matters: cold, wet hollows and thin rocky ridges underperform a deep, gentle slope.

— A Nova Scotia Example

At Little Tree Farm, we grow black walnut seedlings in Nova Scotia — well beyond the species' natural Canadian range.

Mature black walnut trees can already be found growing successfully across the province in parks, farmyards, old homesteads, shelterbelts, and private woodlots. These trees demonstrate that black walnut can perform well outside its native range when planted on a suitable site.

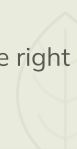
Nova Scotia is not unique in this respect. Similar opportunities exist in other parts of southern Canada where the growing season, soil, drainage, and local climate are favourable.

Not every property will be suitable, even within a region where mature black walnuts are already growing. Before ordering trees, take time to evaluate your soil, drainage, sunlight, exposure, and available growing space. The next chapter will help you do exactly that.



GOOD SITE = GOOD START

The biggest factor influencing success isn't the age of the seedlings or even the weather — it's choosing the right site before planting.





Is Your Land Suitable?



One of the biggest mistakes new growers make is assuming that if a tree is hardy enough to survive, it is suitable for timber production. There is an important difference.

A black walnut tree may survive on a poor site for decades, but if the goal is to grow straight, healthy, high-quality timber, selecting the right location is one of the most important decisions you will make.

Unlike annual crops, you cannot easily move a timber orchard after it has been planted. Spending a few hours evaluating your property before planting can save years of disappointment.

— Soil

Black walnut performs best on deep, fertile soils with plenty of room for roots to develop. Ideal soils are typically:

- ✓ Deep loam
- ✓ Sandy loam
- ✓ Silt loam
- ✓ Fertile former farmland
- ✓ Soils with plenty of organic matter

Healthy soil allows roots to grow deeply, improves drought tolerance, and supports faster growth throughout the life of the plantation. While black walnut can tolerate a range of soil types, growth is usually slower on poor or shallow soils.

— Drainage

If there is one site condition that deserves special attention, it is drainage. **Black walnut does not like wet feet.**

Roots require oxygen to remain healthy. Soils that stay saturated for long periods can reduce growth, increase stress, and eventually kill young trees. Good drainage usually means:

- ✓ Water disappears within a day or two after heavy rain.
- ✓ The ground is firm enough to walk on during spring.
- ✓ Water does not remain standing in low areas.

If parts of your property regularly flood or remain soggy after rain, consider planting another species better suited to those conditions.

— Sunlight

Black walnut is a sun-loving tree. For the best timber growth, trees should be planted in open areas where they receive full sunlight throughout the day.

Avoid planting beside existing forests where larger trees will quickly shade young seedlings. Shade reduces growth and encourages poor form.

If you're converting an old pasture or hay field into a timber orchard, you're already starting with one of the best situations possible.

— Slope and Air Drainage

A gentle slope is often an advantage. Cold air naturally flows downhill and collects in low pockets. These frost pockets can increase the risk of late spring frost damage to newly emerging leaves.

Sites with gentle air movement and good drainage tend to provide more consistent growing conditions than enclosed depressions. Steep slopes are not necessarily unsuitable, but they may make mowing, spraying, pruning, and harvesting more difficult over the life of the orchard.

— Problem Sites

Some sites present challenges that are difficult or expensive to overcome. Think carefully before planting on:

- ✎ Permanently wet ground
- ✎ Heavy clay with poor drainage
- ✎ Shallow soils over bedrock
- ✎ Very dry sandy ridges
- ✎ Areas prone to frequent flooding
- ✎ Frost pockets where cold air settles
- ✎ Land heavily shaded by mature trees

Choosing the wrong site can limit growth for the lifetime of the plantation.

— Walk Your Property

Before ordering seedlings, spend an hour walking the area you plan to plant. Ask yourself:

- ✎ Does the site receive full sun?
- ✎ Is the soil reasonably deep and fertile?
- ✎ Does water drain away after heavy rain?
- ✎ Can equipment access the site for mowing and maintenance?
- ✎ Is there enough space to expand if you decide to plant more trees in the future?

If you can answer "yes" to most of these questions, your property may be an excellent candidate for a black walnut orchard.

Remember, you're not just planting trees — you're selecting a site that may support them for the next 50 years or more.



QUICK SITE ASSESSMENT

- ☐ Full sun for most of the day
- ☐ Well-drained soil
- ☐ No standing water
- ☐ Deep, fertile topsoil
- ☐ Access for mowing and maintenance
- ☐ Enough room for future thinning

If you checked most of these boxes, your site is worth considering for black walnut.

*"Good timber is grown long before the sawmill – it starts with
selecting the right site."*





Planning Your Orchard



One of the first questions most landowners ask is: "How many black walnut trees should I plant?"

The answer depends on your goals, but for growing high-quality timber, we recommend a planting system that balances early competition with room for future management.

— Our Recommended Planting System

Throughout this guide, we use the following planting layout:

- 🌿 **Spacing:** 14 × 14 feet
- 🌿 **Trees per acre:** approximately 222
- 🌿 **Purpose:** grow straight, vigorous trees while allowing gradual thinning over time

This spacing provides enough room for healthy early growth while creating the competition needed to encourage tall, straight stems.

Remember, these 222 trees are **not** all intended to remain until harvest. As the plantation matures, selected trees will be removed during thinning operations, leaving approximately **43 carefully chosen crop trees per acre** at a final spacing of about **32 × 32 feet**.

Think of the first planting as establishing a team of young trees. Over time, you gradually select the strongest individuals to become your final timber crop.

HOW MANY TREES DOES THAT MEAN?

PLANTING AREA	TREES REQUIRED
¼ acre	56 trees
½ acre	111 trees
1 acre	222 trees
2 acres	444 trees
5 acres	1,110 trees
10 acres	2,220 trees
20 acres	4,440 trees

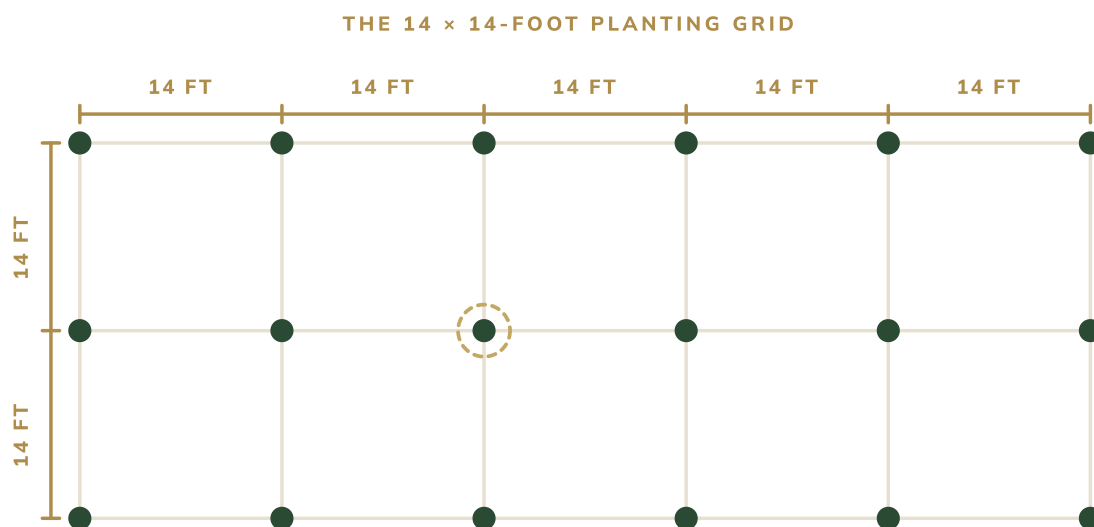
These figures are approximate and allow for square planting at 14-foot spacing.

— Why Not Plant Fewer Trees?

It may seem logical to give every tree plenty of space from the beginning. For timber production, however, wider initial spacing often creates the opposite of what you want. Trees growing without nearby competition tend to:

- Develop larger, lower branches
- Produce wider, shorter crowns
- Grow with heavier taper
- Form wood with more knots

These characteristics reduce the amount of clear, high-quality timber that can eventually be produced. Planting more trees initially allows the orchard to develop naturally before the best trees are selected and retained.



A 14 × 14-foot grid provides approximately 222 planting positions per acre and creates the competition needed to grow straighter timber trees.

— Planning Your Orchard

Before ordering seedlings, sketch your planting area. Consider:

- Property boundaries
- Existing fences
- Access lanes
- Driveways
- Buildings
- Utility lines
- Wet areas
- Future expansion

A simple plan on paper often reveals opportunities or challenges that are easy to overlook when standing in the field. It is also wise to leave enough room for equipment to mow between rows, inspect trees, and carry out pruning and thinning as the plantation matures.

— Think Beyond the First Year

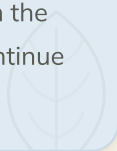
A black walnut orchard changes over time. The layout you establish today will influence every future management decision — from mowing and pruning to thinning and harvesting.

Taking the time to measure your planting area carefully and establish straight, evenly spaced rows is one of the simplest ways to set your orchard up for long-term success.



DID YOU KNOW?

The trees you remove during future thinning are not "mistakes." They are part of the management plan from the very beginning. Early competition helps produce straighter stems, while thinning allows the best trees to continue growing into valuable crop trees.



BEFORE YOU ORDER SEEDLINGS

- ☐ Measure the planting area.
- ☐ Mark corners and boundaries.
- ☐ Identify wet spots.
- ☐ Plan access for mowing and future maintenance.
- ☐ Calculate the number of trees you'll need.

If we're planning to remove many of these trees later, why plant so many in the first place? The answer lies in how trees compete with one another.





Why Tight Spacing Matters



At first glance, planting 222 black walnut trees per acre may seem crowded.

After all, if the goal is to end up with only about 43 mature crop trees per acre, why not simply plant them at their final spacing from the beginning? The answer lies in how trees respond to competition.

— Trees Compete With One Another

In a natural forest, trees compete every day. They compete for:

- ☛ Sunlight
- ☛ Water
- ☛ Nutrients
- ☛ Growing space

As neighbouring trees grow taller, each one invests more energy into reaching the light above the canopy. Instead of producing wide, spreading crowns, young trees naturally grow taller and straighter.

This is exactly what a timber grower wants. Rather than fighting competition, a well-managed black walnut orchard uses it to produce better-quality stems.

— Straight Stems Mean Better Timber

The most valuable timber trees are typically those with:

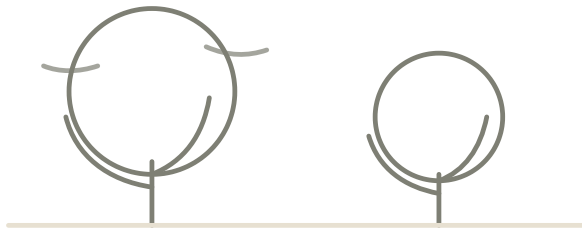
- ☛ Long, straight trunks
- ☛ Minimal taper
- ☛ Few large branches
- ☛ Clear wood free from knots over much of the stem

Trees growing too far apart often develop large side branches that remain alive for many years. As those branches become larger, they leave larger knots within the wood. For timber production, those knots reduce the amount of clear, high-quality lumber or veneer that can be produced.

By planting trees closer together, the developing canopy naturally shades the lower branches. As those branches lose access to sunlight, they die and eventually fall away or can be removed through careful pruning. Over time, this produces longer sections of clear stem — one of the defining characteristics of premium timber.

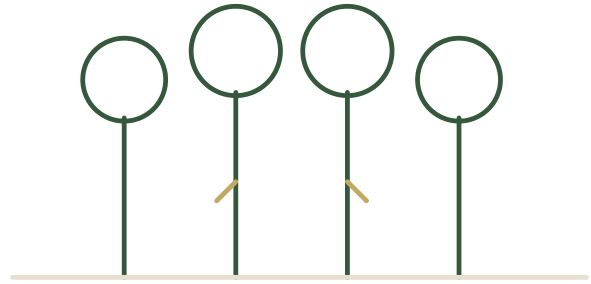


WIDE SPACING



- Large lower branches
- Short clear stem
- More knots

14 × 14 PLANTING



- Competition → tall straight stems
- Lower branches shaded out
- Long clear trunk

Competition between closely planted trees encourages straight stems, natural pruning, and clear, high-value timber.

— Competition Helps You Select the Best Trees

Another advantage of planting more trees than you plan to keep is choice. Not every seedling will grow at the same rate. Some trees will develop excellent form, while others may have:

- Crooked stems
- Forked leaders
- Storm damage
- Insect or disease damage
- Slower growth

Starting with a larger population allows you to gradually remove poorer trees and concentrate future growth on the strongest individuals. Instead of hoping every tree is perfect, you allow the orchard to show you which trees deserve to become your final crop trees.

— The Goal Is Balance

Competition is beneficial — but only up to a point. If trees remain crowded for too long, growth begins to slow as they compete too intensely for light and resources. This is why pruning and thinning are essential parts of managing a black walnut plantation.

The goal is not to keep the plantation crowded forever. The goal is to use early competition to improve stem quality, then gradually provide more growing space to the best trees as they mature.

— Plant With the End in Mind

When you plant your orchard, it helps to think several decades ahead. The young seedlings you place in the ground today are creating the conditions needed for the future crop trees you hope to harvest many years from now.

Every tree has a purpose. Some will become your final timber trees. Others will help shape those trees before eventually being removed through planned thinning. That is not wasted effort — it is part of growing quality hardwood timber.



GOOD TIMBER STARTS YOUNG

The shape of a mature black walnut tree is influenced during its first 10–20 years. Early spacing, pruning, and competition have lasting effects on timber quality decades later.



RESEARCH SAYS

Modern hardwood management recognizes that quality timber is grown through active management — not simply by planting trees and waiting. Careful spacing, timely pruning, and planned thinning work together to improve the likelihood of producing straight, high-quality stems.



The First 10 Years



Planting a black walnut orchard is an exciting milestone, but it is only the beginning.

The first decade is when your management decisions have the greatest influence on the future quality of your trees. A well-managed plantation can develop straight, vigorous stems with excellent potential for future timber production. A neglected plantation may struggle for decades to recover.

The good news is that black walnut does not require constant attention. The key is to focus on the right tasks at the right time.

— Planting

Healthy seedlings establish best when planted during the dormant season, typically in early spring. Before planting:

- Keep roots cool and moist.
- Never allow roots to dry out.
- Plant as soon as practical after receiving your seedlings.
- Handle seedlings carefully to avoid damaging roots or stems.

Each tree should be planted at approximately the same depth it was growing in the nursery. Roots should spread naturally in the planting hole rather than being bent upward or crowded into a small space. After planting, gently firm the soil around the roots to remove large air pockets.



PLANTING DAY TIPS

- Keep roots moist.
- Plant as soon as practical.
- Never leave seedlings exposed to sun or wind.
- Firm soil gently around roots.



— Weed Control

If there is one practice that consistently improves young tree growth, it is effective weed control. Grass and weeds compete aggressively with young walnut seedlings for moisture, nutrients, and sunlight. During the first several years, this competition can slow growth far more than many new growers expect.

Common approaches include:

- Mulch around individual trees
- Herbicide programs where appropriate and permitted

- 🌱 Mechanical cultivation
- 🌱 Regular mowing between rows to reduce competition

The objective is not to eliminate every weed across the property. Instead, focus on reducing competition immediately around each young tree.



The same species planted on the same day can grow very differently depending on weed competition. Keep a weed-free circle around each young tree.

— Watering

Established black walnut trees are relatively drought tolerant, but newly planted seedlings benefit from consistent soil moisture while their root systems develop. During prolonged dry periods:

- 🌱 Water deeply rather than frequently.
- 🌱 Encourage moisture to soak into the root zone.
- 🌱 Avoid frequent shallow watering that promotes surface roots.

Once established, most plantations rely primarily on natural rainfall, although irrigation can improve survival and early growth during unusually dry seasons.



WATER LESS OFTEN — BUT MORE DEEPLY

Deep watering encourages deeper root development than frequent shallow watering.

— Protecting Young Trees

Young black walnut seedlings can attract unwanted attention from wildlife. Depending on your location, damage may come from:

- 🌱 Deer browsing
- 🌱 Rabbits
- 🌱 Mice and voles
- 🌱 Livestock
- 🌱 Equipment during mowing

Tree shelters, protective guards, fencing, or repellents may be worthwhile where browsing pressure is high. Just as important, take care when mowing or using string trimmers around young trees. Mechanical damage to bark can permanently affect future timber quality.



SMALL DAMAGE TODAY CAN LAST A LIFETIME

A mower wound or broken leader during the first few years can permanently reduce timber quality decades later.

— Pruning

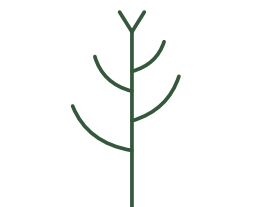
Pruning is one of the most valuable investments you can make in a timber orchard. The objective is not to create a perfectly shaped landscape tree. Instead, pruning encourages one straight central leader and helps produce a long section of clear, knot-free stem.

During the early years:

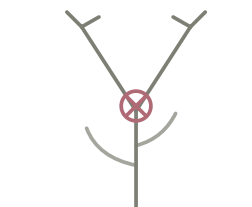
- Maintain a single dominant leader whenever possible.
- Remove broken or damaged branches.
- Correct forks while they are still small.
- Make clean pruning cuts without leaving stubs.
- Avoid removing too much of the live crown in a single season.

Small corrective pruning performed regularly is generally easier — and better for the tree — than major pruning later.

GOOD — ONE LEADER



POOR — FORKED



Maintain a single dominant leader. Correct forks while they are still small and easy to manage.

— Monitor Growth

Spend time walking through your plantation each year. Look for:

- Healthy annual growth
- Insect or disease problems
- Broken leaders
- Storm damage
- Areas with poor drainage
- Trees that are struggling

Early problems are usually easier to correct than problems that have been ignored for several years. Keeping simple notes or photographs each season can also help you track the development of your plantation over time.



TAKE PHOTOS EVERY YEAR

Standing in the same location each spring and photographing your orchard creates an excellent long-term record of growth.

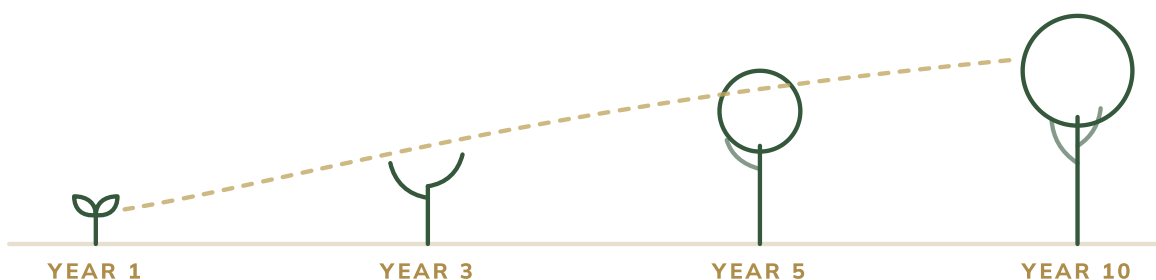
— Be Patient

During the first few years, much of a black walnut tree's energy goes into developing its root system. Top growth may seem slower than expected at first.

As roots expand and trees become established, growth often becomes more vigorous. Every site is different, and weather conditions vary from year to year, so avoid comparing your plantation too closely with photographs from other regions.

Healthy, steady growth is more important than rapid growth.

THE GROWING YEARS



Much of the first years' energy goes underground. Steady establishment beats rapid early growth.

— Success Comes From Consistency

There is no single management technique that guarantees a high-quality timber tree. Rather, success comes from doing many small things well:

- ✎ Planting carefully
- ✎ Controlling weeds
- ✎ Protecting young trees
- ✎ Pruning thoughtfully
- ✎ Monitoring the plantation each year

These simple practices, repeated consistently over time, help create the conditions needed for straight, healthy crop trees that can continue improving for decades to come.

★ SPRING

- Plant seedlings
- Check survival
- Replace losses

☀ SUMMER

- Weed control
- Water if needed
- Watch for damage

🍂 AUTUMN

- Walk the plantation
- Record progress
- Note problem trees

❄ WINTER

- Plan pruning
- Plan maintenance
- Order replacements



THE FIRST THREE YEARS MATTER MOST

Young black walnut seedlings face their greatest challenges during establishment. Good weed control, protection from damage, and proper planting often have a greater impact on long-term success than anything you do later.



ANNUAL ORCHARD CHECKLIST

- ☐ Walk every row.
- ☐ Check tree survival.
- ☐ Remove competing vegetation.
- ☐ Inspect for wildlife damage.
- ☐ Correct forked leaders.
- ☐ Replace dead trees if needed.
- ☐ Record observations with notes or photos.

There is no secret formula – successful orchards are built through many small decisions made consistently over time.



Thinning: Growing the Best by Removing the Rest



One of the most surprising things about growing a black walnut timber orchard is that not every tree you plant is meant to remain forever.

In fact, one of the keys to producing high-quality timber is knowing **which trees to remove, when to remove them, and why**. When your orchard is planted at 14 × 14 feet (approximately 222 trees per acre), every tree has a purpose. During the early years, neighbouring trees compete for sunlight, encouraging straighter stems, smaller side branches, and natural self-pruning.

As the crowns expand and begin to close, that same competition eventually shifts from being beneficial to becoming limiting. Recognizing this transition is one of the keys to successful black walnut management. That is when thinning becomes an important management tool.

— What Is Thinning?

Thinning is the planned removal of selected trees to give the remaining trees more space, light, water, and nutrients. Rather than allowing nature to decide which trees survive, the landowner chooses the trees with the greatest long-term potential.

Think of it as investing your land's resources in the very best trees.

— Why Thin?

Without thinning, trees eventually become overcrowded. Crowded plantations may experience:

- ❖ Slower diameter growth
- ❖ Greater stress during dry periods
- ❖ Smaller crowns
- ❖ Reduced vigour
- ❖ Increased competition for water and nutrients

Proper thinning redirects growth into the remaining crop trees, allowing them to continue increasing in diameter while maintaining healthy crowns.

— Understanding Canopy Closure

One of the easiest ways to tell when your plantation is approaching its first thinning is by watching the tree crowns. As young black walnut trees grow, their branches gradually expand until neighbouring crowns begin to touch. Foresters refer to this as **canopy closure**.



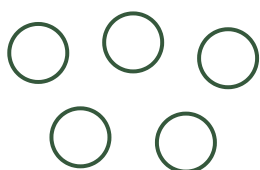
During the years leading up to canopy closure, competition between trees is beneficial. It encourages trees to grow taller, develop straighter stems, and naturally shed lower branches. Once the canopy has closed, however, competition becomes much more intense. Trees begin competing heavily for sunlight, water, and nutrients. Diameter growth slows, and weaker trees may become suppressed by their neighbours.

This is the stage when it is time to start thinking about thinning. Rather than waiting until trees are overcrowded and struggling, thinning is used to reduce competition and provide the best crop trees with the growing space they need to continue increasing in diameter.

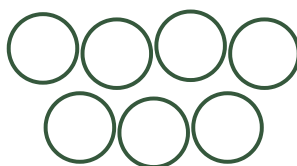
Canopy closure does not occur at exactly the same age in every plantation. On fertile sites with excellent growing conditions, it may happen sooner than on poorer sites. The important point is to observe how your trees are developing rather than relying on a specific number of years.

As your plantation matures, regular walks through the orchard will help you recognize when neighbouring crowns are beginning to compete. That visual change is often one of the clearest signals that it's time to evaluate your stand for thinning.

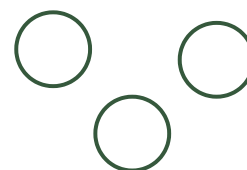
BEFORE CLOSURE



CLOSURE BEGINS



AFTER THINNING



Canopy closure is a natural stage in the development of a timber plantation. Planned thinning after closure keeps growth concentrated on the best crop trees.

— Which Trees Should Be Removed?

Every plantation is different, but thinning usually begins by removing trees that have:

- ❖ Crooked or leaning stems
- ❖ Forked leaders
- ❖ Poor form
- ❖ Storm damage
- ❖ Insect or disease damage
- ❖ Slow growth compared with neighbouring trees
- ❖ Crowns being overtopped by healthier trees

The objective is not simply to reduce the number of trees. The objective is to improve the quality of the trees that remain.

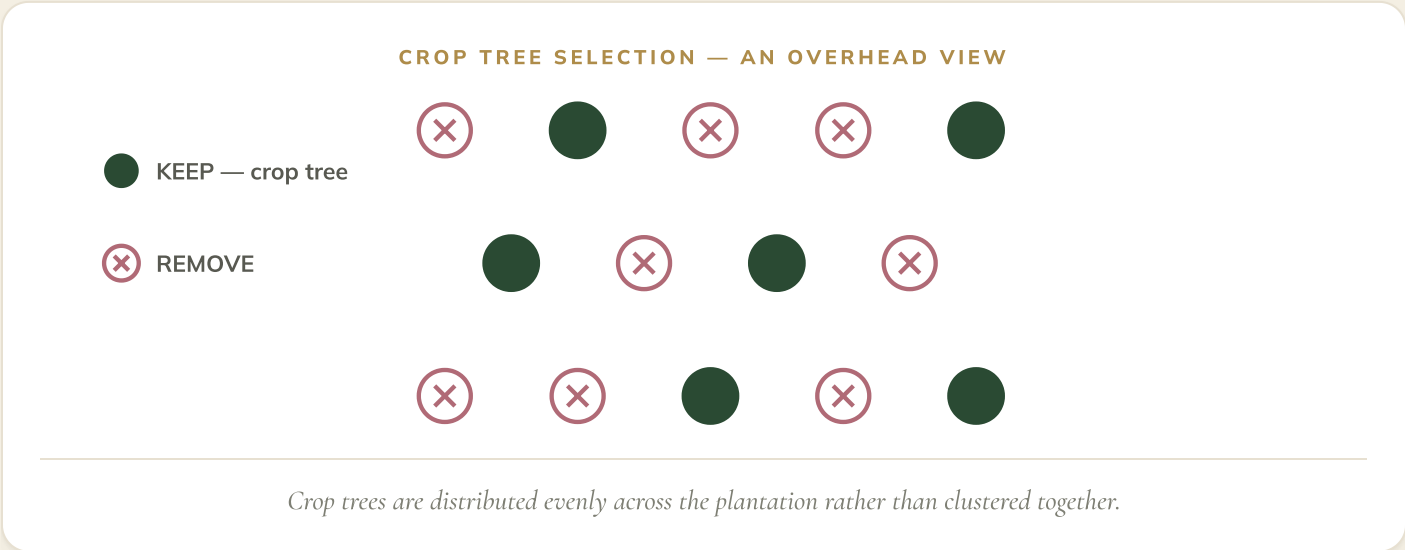
— Choosing Crop Trees

As your plantation matures, certain trees will begin to stand out. These are your future crop trees. Look for trees with:

- ❖ A straight central stem
- ❖ Good height growth
- ❖ Healthy crowns
- ❖ Minimal damage

- Good spacing from neighbouring crop trees
- Strong overall vigour

These trees receive priority during future management decisions. Everything else is managed to support their development.



— A Gradual Process

Thinning is rarely completed all at once. Instead, it is usually carried out over several decades as the plantation develops. A typical progression might look like this:

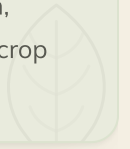
THE THINNING JOURNEY	
STAGE	APPROXIMATE TREES PER ACRE
Planting	222
Early thinning	150–180
Intermediate thinning	90–120
Later thinning	60–80
Final crop trees	Approximately 43

These numbers are examples rather than strict rules. The exact timing and intensity of thinning depend on tree growth, site quality, management objectives, and local conditions.



EVERY TREE HAS A JOB

The trees removed during thinning are not "wasted." During their early years they helped create competition, encouraged straighter stems, reduced large side branches, and allowed you to identify the strongest future crop trees.



— Every Tree Has Value

Although the ultimate goal is to grow high-quality sawlogs or veneer logs, trees removed during thinning may still have value. Depending on their size and local markets, thinnings may be used for:

- Firewood
- Woodworking projects
- Small sawlogs
- Fence posts
- Craft wood
- Wildlife habitat

Even when removed trees have little commercial value, they have still played an important role by helping shape the future crop trees.

— Think Long-Term

When you walk through a young plantation, it can feel difficult to remove healthy trees. Remember that thinning is not about cutting good trees. It is about giving the **best** trees the opportunity to become exceptional.

The decisions you make during thinning influence the quality, growth, and value of your future timber crop for decades to come.



DON'T WAIT TOO LONG

Delaying thinning for many years after the canopy has become overcrowded can reduce diameter growth and make it more difficult for selected crop trees to respond.

Regular observation and timely management usually produce better results than waiting until the plantation becomes heavily crowded.



BEFORE YOUR FIRST THINNING

- ☐ Walk the plantation carefully.
- ☐ Identify the straightest trees.
- ☐ Mark future crop trees.
- ☐ Remove poor-quality stems first.
- ☐ Keep records of thinning dates and observations.
- ☐ Review the plantation every few years as it develops.



A Black Walnut Orchard Timeline



Growing black walnut is a long-term project.

Unlike annual crops or even many fruit trees, a timber orchard develops gradually over several decades. Each stage brings new opportunities, different management priorities, and visible changes to the plantation.

The timeline below provides a general overview of what you can expect. Every property is different, and the timing of each stage will vary depending on climate, soil, rainfall, and management. The important thing is not how quickly your trees grow, but that they continue to grow steadily and remain healthy.



— Year 0 — Planning and Planting

This is where your orchard begins. Before the first tree goes into the ground, time spent planning will pay dividends for years to come.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

- ▮ Bare-root seedlings planted in straight rows.
- ▮ Plenty of open space between trees.
- ▮ Little visible growth during the first season.

YOUR PRIORITIES

- ▮ Plant seedlings correctly.
- ▮ Keep roots moist during planting.
- ▮ Control weeds around each tree.
- ▮ Water during extended dry periods if necessary.
- ▮ Protect young trees from wildlife and equipment damage.

— Years 1-5 — Establishment

During these early years, much of the tree's energy is directed below ground as the root system develops. Top growth may appear slower than expected at first, but healthy root development is laying the foundation for future growth.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

- ▮ Steady height growth.
- ▮ Developing root systems.
- ▮ Trees beginning to form a strong central leader.

YOUR PRIORITIES

- ▮ Maintain good weed control.
- ▮ Replace dead trees if necessary.
- ▮ Correct forked leaders early.
- ▮ Inspect the plantation at least once each year.

— Years 5–10 — Building the Plantation

The orchard begins to look more like a young forest. Trees become taller, lower branches begin to shade one another, and competition for sunlight gradually increases.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

- 🌱 Rapid height growth.
- 🌱 Straighter stems developing.
- 🌱 Crowns expanding toward neighbouring trees.
- 🌱 Natural self-pruning beginning on lower branches.

YOUR PRIORITIES

- 🌱 Continue corrective pruning where needed.
- 🌱 Monitor tree health and growth.
- 🌱 Watch for the early signs of canopy closure.
- 🌱 Keep records of your plantation's progress.

— Years 10–20 — Competition and First Thinning

As neighbouring tree crowns begin to touch, competition becomes much stronger. This stage marks an important transition in the life of the plantation. Rather than allowing overcrowding to slow growth, many landowners begin evaluating the orchard for its first thinning.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

- 🌱 Canopy closure beginning.
- 🌱 Increased competition between trees.
- 🌱 Strong differences in tree quality becoming apparent.

YOUR PRIORITIES

- 🌱 Identify future crop trees.
- 🌱 Remove poor-quality stems where appropriate.
- 🌱 Continue monitoring growth and tree health.

— Years 20–40 — Developing Future Crop Trees

The plantation now contains fewer trees, but the remaining crop trees have significantly more room to grow. Management focuses on maintaining healthy crowns and encouraging steady diameter growth.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

- 🌱 Larger tree trunks.
- 🌱 Healthy, expanding crowns.
- 🌱 More space between selected crop trees.
- 🌱 A well-managed timber plantation taking shape.

YOUR PRIORITIES

- 🌱 Continue selective thinning as needed.
- 🌱 Protect valuable crop trees from damage.
- 🌱 Monitor overall plantation health.

— 40 Years and Beyond — A Long-Term Legacy

By this stage, years of planning and careful management have shaped the plantation. Depending on your goals, some landowners may continue growing trees for additional decades, while others may begin harvesting selected trees as markets and objectives allow.

There is no single "right" age to harvest a black walnut tree. Site quality, tree size, timber quality, and market demand all influence those decisions.

For many families, a black walnut orchard becomes more than a timber investment. It becomes a lasting feature of the property — one that can provide wildlife habitat, beauty, shade, and opportunities for future generations.



BLACK WALNUT IS MEASURED IN DECADES

One of the greatest advantages of growing timber is that trees continue growing while you own them. Unlike many agricultural crops, a black walnut orchard is not managed on an annual production cycle — it develops gradually over many years.



LITTLE TREE FARM TIP

Don't become discouraged if your plantation looks small after the first few years. Healthy root development, straight stems, and consistent management are far more important than rapid early height growth.

— Every Orchard Is Different

No two plantations develop at exactly the same pace. Growing conditions, weather, soil quality, and management all influence how quickly an orchard matures. Rather than comparing your trees with someone else's, focus on keeping your plantation healthy, well-managed, and steadily improving over time.

Good management is measured over decades — not seasons.

THE JOURNEY AT A GLANCE

STAGE	YOUR FOCUS
Planting	Get off to a good start
Years 1–5	Establish healthy trees
Years 5–10	Maintain and monitor
Years 10–20	Watch for canopy closure and begin thinning
Years 20–40	Develop future crop trees
40+ Years	Manage according to your long-term goals



Common Mistakes (and How to Avoid Them)



Growing a successful black walnut orchard is not about being a forestry expert. It is about making good decisions consistently over time.

Most problems don't happen because people planted black walnut. They happen because the trees were planted on unsuitable sites or received too little attention during their early years. Fortunately, many of the most common mistakes are easy to avoid.



1

Planting on the Wrong Site

No amount of pruning, fertilizing, or careful management can completely overcome a poor planting site. Black walnut performs best on deep, fertile, well-drained soils with full sun. Before ordering seedlings, take time to evaluate your property honestly. If part of your land is poorly drained or frequently flooded, consider planting another tree species better suited to those conditions. **It's better to plant fewer trees on an excellent site than more trees on a poor one.**

2

Underestimating Weed Competition

Young black walnut seedlings are surprisingly sensitive to competition from grass and weeds. A thick layer of grass around each seedling can reduce available moisture and nutrients, slowing growth during the years when the trees are becoming established. Maintaining a weed-free area around each tree during the first few years is one of the simplest ways to encourage healthy growth.

3

Planting Too Far Apart

A common assumption is that giving every tree plenty of space will produce larger, healthier trees. For timber production, however, this often leads to wider crowns, larger lower branches, and more knots in the wood. Planting at approximately **14 × 14 feet (222 trees per acre)** encourages the early competition needed to produce straighter stems. As the plantation matures, thinning provides the remaining crop trees with additional growing space.

4

Ignoring Forked Leaders

Young black walnut trees occasionally develop two competing leaders instead of one straight central stem. If left uncorrected, these forks can reduce timber quality and create structural weaknesses. Inspect your plantation each year and correct developing forks while they are still small and easy to manage. Small corrections made early are usually much easier than major pruning later.

5

Waiting Too Long to Thin

Competition between young trees is beneficial — up to a point. Once canopy closure begins and trees become crowded, growth slows as competition increases. Regularly observing your plantation allows you to recognize when neighbouring crowns begin competing for space. Timely thinning helps direct future growth into your best crop trees.

6

Expecting Quick Returns

Perhaps the biggest mistake is expecting black walnut to produce rapid financial returns. A timber orchard is a long-term investment in your land. The greatest rewards often come from decades of steady growth, thoughtful management, and patience. Many landowners choose to plant black walnut not only for its timber potential, but also for the satisfaction of improving their property, creating wildlife habitat, and leaving something meaningful for future generations.

— Mistakes Are Part of Learning

Every experienced grower has made mistakes. The important thing is to learn from them, observe your plantation, and continue improving your management over time.

Black walnut is remarkably resilient when planted on a suitable site and given good early care. Focus on the fundamentals, stay patient, and remember that successful timber growing is measured over decades — not by what happens in a single season.

SMALL DECISIONS, BIG RESULTS

GOOD SITE → WEED CONTROL → SINGLE LEADER → TIMELY THINNING → HEALTHY CROP TREE

Success comes from a series of good decisions rather than one "secret" technique.



COMMON MISCONCEPTION — BIGGER ISN'T ALWAYS BETTER

Many people assume planting trees farther apart will produce better timber. For black walnut, the opposite is often true. Early competition encourages straighter stems and better natural pruning, while planned thinning later provides the remaining crop trees with the space they need to continue growing.



LITTLE TREE FARM TIP

Walk your plantation at least once each season. Most issues — whether it's a forked leader, wildlife damage, or poor drainage — are much easier to correct when spotted early.

A Simple Long-Term Investment Example



One of the reasons people become interested in black walnut is its reputation as a valuable hardwood.

Well-grown black walnut has long been sought after for furniture, cabinetry, architectural woodwork, veneer, gunstocks, musical instruments, and many other specialty wood products. High-quality logs have historically commanded premium prices compared with many other North American hardwoods.

However, it is important to understand that **not every black walnut tree becomes a valuable timber tree**. The quality of the final log depends on many factors, including:

- The planting site
- Soil quality
- Climate
- Genetics
- Weed control during establishment
- Pruning
- Thinning
- Tree health
- Timber markets at the time of harvest

Good management improves the likelihood of producing high-quality timber, but it does not guarantee a particular financial outcome.

— Quality Creates Opportunity

Imagine two landowners each plant one acre of black walnut. Both begin with approximately **222 seedlings** planted at **14 × 14-foot spacing**.

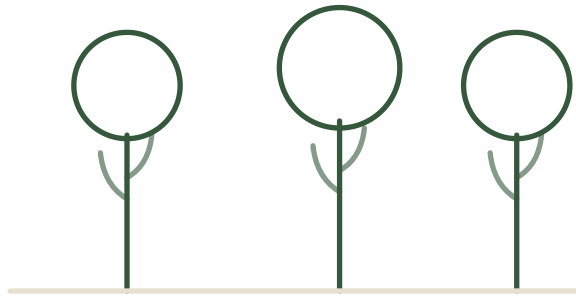
One plantation receives regular attention:

- Good weed control
- Corrective pruning
- Timely thinning
- Regular inspections
- Protection from damage

The second plantation is largely left unmanaged.

After several decades, both properties contain mature black walnut trees — but the results may look very different. The well-managed plantation is more likely to contain straight stems, longer sections of clear wood, healthy crowns, and well-spaced crop trees. The unmanaged plantation may contain crooked stems, persistent large branches, crowded trees, and slower-growing individuals.

WELL-MANAGED



Straight stems · clear wood · well-spaced crop trees

UNMANAGED



Crooked stems · large branches · crowded trees

Both plantations grew black walnut. Only one consistently invested in quality. The difference is not the species — it is the management.

— Think of Management as an Investment

Many of the tasks involved in growing a timber orchard — such as mowing, pruning, and thinning — do not produce immediate financial returns. Instead, they are investments in the future quality of the trees. Small management decisions made during the first 10 to 20 years often influence timber quality for the remainder of the plantation's life.

MANAGEMENT OVER TIME

GOOD SITE → GOOD PLANTING → WEED CONTROL → PRUNING → THINNING → QUALITY TREES

Value is built step by step — each practice compounds the one before it.

— Markets Change

No one can predict timber prices 30, 40, or 50 years into the future. Markets rise and fall, demand changes, and the value of individual trees depends on both timber quality and local market conditions.

For that reason, black walnut should not be planted based on the expectation of a guaranteed financial return. Instead, many landowners choose to plant black walnut because it offers several potential benefits:

- A productive long-term use of underutilized land.
- The possibility of growing valuable hardwood timber.
- Wildlife habitat and biodiversity.
- Shade and landscape value.

🌿 A lasting legacy for future generations.



THERE ARE NO GUARANTEES

Timber markets, weather, and tree growth all vary over time. This guide is intended to help you improve the quality of your plantation, not predict future financial returns.

— Looking Beyond Dollars

For many families, the greatest return is not measured only in timber value. It is measured in knowing that they improved their land, planted a native hardwood that may outlive them, and left something of lasting value for their children and grandchildren.

A black walnut orchard is an investment in both the future of your property and the generations that follow.



LITTLE TREE FARM TIP

If your primary goal is quick income, a black walnut orchard is probably not the right project. If your goal is improving your land while growing a valuable hardwood over the long term, black walnut can be a rewarding choice.

*Quality timber is the result of decades of careful management
— not chance.*



Equipment and Site Preparation



By this stage, you've learned how a black walnut orchard develops, why spacing matters, and how to manage young trees during their first decade. Now it's time to prepare for planting.

A little planning before the first seedling goes into the ground can make planting day easier, improve establishment, and save many hours of work over the years that follow.

The amount of preparation required will depend on your property. A well-maintained hay field may need very little work, while rough pasture, brush-covered land, or recently cleared areas may require additional preparation. The goal isn't to create a perfect seedbed — it's to create the best possible conditions for young trees to establish and for the orchard to be managed efficiently in the future.

— Preparing Your Site

Before ordering seedlings, take a walk across the planting area and look at it through the eyes of someone who will be managing the orchard for the next 40 years. Ask yourself:

- Is the area accessible with equipment?
- Are there wet or poorly drained areas to avoid?
- Can I mow between the rows?
- Is there enough room to turn equipment at the end of each row?
- Are fences, power lines, or buildings going to affect the layout?
- Have I allowed room for future maintenance and thinning?

Spending a little extra time planning now often prevents much larger problems later.

— Preparing the Ground

Every property is different, so there is no single "correct" way to prepare a planting site. Depending on your soil and previous land use, preparation may include:

- Mowing tall grass or vegetation.
- Rototilling or cultivating planting rows.
- Removing brush or unwanted shrubs.
- Spot cultivation around each planting location.
- Ploughing where appropriate.
- Planting directly into well-managed pasture or former cropland.

Good drainage and weed control are usually far more important than creating a perfectly cultivated field. **Avoid working wet soils**, as this can cause compaction and reduce soil structure.



FIELD NOTE — THINK ABOUT FUTURE MAINTENANCE

Straight rows aren't just visually appealing. They make mowing, inspections, pruning, spraying (where appropriate), thinning, and harvesting much easier throughout the life of the plantation.

A few extra minutes spent measuring rows on planting day can save many hours of work over the coming decades.



— Equipment Checklist

Not every grower needs every piece of equipment. Someone planting half an acre may only require a few hand tools, while larger plantations often benefit from tractors and mechanical equipment. Choose the tools that best suit the size of your project.



ESSENTIAL EQUIPMENT — USEFUL FOR ALMOST EVERY PROJECT

- ☐ Planting spade or tree planting shovel
- ☐ Dibble bar (planting bar) for suitable soils
- ☐ Measuring tape
- ☐ String line
- ☐ Stakes or flags for marking rows
- ☐ Pruning secateurs
- ☐ Buckets or containers for carrying seedlings
- ☐ Water supply during dry conditions
- ☐ Work gloves and sturdy footwear



HELPFUL FOR LARGER PLANTINGS

- ☐ Tractor
- ☐ Front-end loader
- ☐ Rototiller
- ☐ Plough
- ☐ Cultivator
- ☐ Mechanical post-hole auger or tractor-mounted auger (for larger planting stock or challenging soils)
- ☐ Trailer
- ☐ Water tank
- ☐ ATV or utility vehicle
- ☐ Brush mower or flail mower



OPTIONAL EQUIPMENT

- ☐ Tree shelters
- ☐ Wildlife guards
- ☐ Mulch
- ☐ Marking paint or forestry ribbon
- ☐ GPS or laser rangefinder for laying out rows
- ☐ Soil probe or shovel for checking soil depth
- ☐ Wheelbarrow or garden cart

Remember, **good planning and careful planting are far more important than owning expensive equipment.**

SIMPLE ORCHARD LAYOUT



Leaving room for equipment to turn at the ends of rows makes mowing, inspections, and future management much easier.

— Before Planting Day

A successful planting day usually begins several days earlier. Before your seedlings arrive, make sure:

- ✓ The site is ready.
- ✓ Rows have been measured and marked.
- ✓ Equipment is fuelled and working.
- ✓ Helpers understand the planting plan.
- ✓ Weather conditions are suitable.
- ✓ A cool, shaded location is available to store seedlings if planting cannot begin immediately.

Bare-root seedlings should never be left exposed to direct sunlight or drying winds. Healthy roots are the foundation of healthy trees.



LITTLE TREE FARM TIP

At Little Tree Farm, we've learned that the smoothest planting days are usually the ones that involve the most preparation. Organizing equipment, measuring rows, and planning the day's work before the seedlings arrive allows you to focus on careful planting rather than solving problems in the field.

— Looking Ahead

Planting day is exciting, but it is only the beginning of your orchard's journey. As you finish preparing your site, it's also worth thinking about the years ahead.

- 🌿 Can you comfortably mow between the rows?
- 🌿 Will equipment be able to access the plantation for pruning and thinning?
- 🌿 Have you left enough space to expand the orchard in the future?

A well-planned plantation is easier to manage, more enjoyable to work in, and better positioned for long-term success.



GOOD PREPARATION PAYS OFF

Most planting problems can be traced back to poor preparation rather than poor seedlings. Planning your layout, preparing the site, and organizing your equipment before planting helps give every tree the best possible start.



BEFORE YOU PLANT — CAN YOU ANSWER "YES"?

- ☐ Is the planting site suitable?
- ☐ Have the rows been measured and marked?
- ☐ Is the necessary equipment ready?
- ☐ Are the seedlings being kept cool and moist?
- ☐ Do you have enough time to complete the planting properly?
- ☐ Have you planned how the orchard will be maintained over the coming years?

If so, you're well prepared to begin establishing your black walnut orchard.



Next Steps: Planning Your Black Walnut Orchard



If you've made it this far, you've already done something many people never do — you've taken the time to learn before planting.

By understanding your site, choosing an appropriate planting layout, and learning the basics of managing a timber orchard, you're already in a much stronger position to succeed. Before ordering seedlings, however, it's worth taking a few moments to plan your project. Good planning today can save time, money, and effort for years to come.

— Is Black Walnut the Right Choice?

Black walnut is a rewarding tree to grow, but it isn't the right choice for every property. Ask yourself:

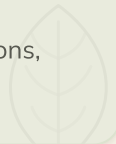
- 🌱 Does my property have well-drained, fertile soil?
- 🌱 Can I provide full sun for the plantation?
- 🌱 Am I prepared to manage the orchard during its early years?
- 🌱 Am I comfortable thinking in decades rather than seasons?

If you answered "yes" to these questions, black walnut may be an excellent fit for your land. If not, another tree species may be better suited to your site and objectives. **The goal is to plant the right tree in the right place.**



START WITH THE RIGHT EXPECTATIONS

A black walnut orchard is a long-term project. Success comes from steady management, realistic expectations, and enjoying the process of watching your plantation develop over time.



— How Much Should You Plant?

One of the most common questions we hear is: "How many acres should I plant?" The answer depends on your goals, available land, budget, and the amount of time you can devote to establishment and maintenance.

There is nothing wrong with starting small. Many successful growers begin with one or two acres, learn how the trees perform on their property, and expand later as their confidence grows. Remember, a well-managed one-acre plantation is often a better investment than a neglected ten-acre plantation.



— Plant All at Once or in Stages?

Both approaches have advantages. Planting everything in one season creates a plantation of the same age and can simplify future management. Planting in stages spreads the work over several years and allows you to gain experience before expanding. Neither approach is right or wrong — choose the option that best matches your time, budget, and long-term plans.

— How Many Seedlings Will You Need?

Using the planting system described in this guide — **14 × 14-foot spacing**, approximately **222 trees per acre** — you can estimate your planting requirements easily.

SEEDLING ESTIMATOR	
PLANTING AREA	APPROXIMATE SEEDLINGS
½ acre	111
1 acre	222
2 acres	444
5 acres	1,110
10 acres	2,220

Ordering a few extra seedlings can be worthwhile if you expect to replace occasional losses during establishment.



— When Should You Order?

Bare-root seedlings are only available during the dormant season. Ordering early generally provides the best selection and gives both you and the nursery time to plan your shipment.

If you're preparing a larger planting, it's often helpful to contact the nursery well in advance so inventory can be discussed before the planting season begins.

— When Should You Plant?

Across much of Canada, bare-root black walnut seedlings are typically planted during the spring while the trees are still dormant. Planting during this period gives seedlings the opportunity to establish roots before the demands of summer.

Weather and local conditions vary from region to region, so planting dates may differ depending on your location.

— Storing Bare-Root Seedlings

If you cannot plant immediately after receiving your seedlings, you can "heel in" your bare-root planting stock until you are ready to plant. To heel in seedlings:

- 🌿 Remove the trees from the plastic wrapping they were shipped in.
- 🌿 Dig a trench in a shaded, protected area.
- 🌿 Lay the seedlings in the trench at approximately a 45-degree angle.
- 🌿 Cover the roots and part of the seedlings with soil.
- 🌿 Water thoroughly to keep the roots moist.

This is the same method used in nursery settings to safely hold bare-root trees before planting. **Healthy roots are essential for successful establishment.**



LITTLE TREE FARM TIP

Try to have your site fully prepared before your seedlings arrive. Planting freshly delivered seedlings as soon as possible is one of the easiest ways to reduce stress and improve establishment.

— Questions to Ask Before Ordering

Whether you're buying from Little Tree Farm or another nursery, don't hesitate to ask questions. Some helpful questions include:

- 🌿 Is black walnut suitable for my location?
- 🌿 What size seedlings do you recommend?
- 🌿 How many seedlings should I order?
- 🌿 When will they be shipped?
- 🌿 How should they be stored if planting is delayed?
- 🌿 What should I do if I have questions after planting?

A good nursery should be happy to help you plan your project — not simply sell you trees.

— Ready to Begin?

By now, you have a solid understanding of how a black walnut timber orchard works. You know how to evaluate your land, choose an appropriate planting layout, understand the importance of early management, and appreciate the long-term nature of growing quality hardwood timber.

The next step is simply deciding when you'd like to begin. Whether you plant one acre or twenty, careful planning and steady management will give your orchard the best opportunity to thrive.

In the final chapter, we'd like to introduce ourselves, explain why we grow black walnut seedlings, and share how Little Tree Farm can help you take the next step in your planting journey.



About Little Tree Farm



If you've reached the final chapter of this guide, thank you.

Growing a black walnut orchard isn't a decision most people make overnight. It takes curiosity, planning, and a willingness to think decades into the future. Whether you decide to plant this year, next year, or simply continue learning, we hope this guide has given you the confidence to better understand what it takes to grow quality black walnut trees. That was our goal from the very beginning.

— Why We Created This Guide

When we first began researching black walnut, we quickly discovered that much of the best information came from the United States. Excellent publications exist from universities, forestry departments, and organizations such as the USDA, Purdue University, the Missouri Department of Conservation, and the Walnut Council.

But very little practical information had been written specifically for Canadian landowners who wanted to establish a black walnut timber orchard. We created this guide to help bridge that gap.

Rather than producing another sales brochure, we wanted to create something practical, honest, and useful — something we would have appreciated having ourselves when we first started learning about black walnut. Our hope is that this guide becomes a resource you return to as your orchard grows.

— Who We Are

Little Tree Farm is a family-owned bare-root nursery located in Wentzell Lake, Nova Scotia. We grow a wide range of native, edible, and specialty trees and shrubs, with a strong focus on species that are well suited to Canadian landscapes.

Every year we sow thousands of seeds, care for young seedlings in the field, and lift bare-root planting stock during the dormant season for customers across Canada.

While every species has its own purpose, black walnut has become one of the trees we're most excited about. It represents something much bigger than simply planting a tree. It represents stewardship. Patience. Long-term thinking. And the opportunity to improve a piece of land for future generations.

Family

OWNED & OPERATED

1000s

SEEDS SOWN EACH YEAR

Bare-root

DORMANT-SEASON STOCK

Canada

COAST-TO-COAST
SHIPPING

— Our Philosophy

We believe that growing trees is about much more than producing seedlings. A healthy seedling is only the beginning. The real success of a nursery is measured years later, when those trees are thriving in fields, woodlots, farms, parks, and communities across the country.

That is why we believe education is just as important as the trees themselves. An informed landowner is far more likely to establish a successful plantation than someone who plants without a plan. If this guide helps even one family avoid common mistakes and grow a healthier black walnut orchard, then it has achieved its purpose.



LITTLE TREE FARM INSIGHT

Our favourite part of growing trees isn't shipping them. It's seeing photographs years later of healthy plantations that started as small bare-root seedlings.

Watching those trees become part of someone's farm, woodlot, or family legacy is one of the most rewarding parts of what we do.



— If You Decide to Plant

If black walnut feels like the right fit for your property, we'd be honoured to help. Whether you're planting a single acre or planning a much larger timber orchard, we're always happy to answer questions and help you think through your project before you place an order.

Sometimes the most valuable advice isn't about choosing a tree — it's deciding whether black walnut is the right choice in the first place. If another species would better suit your site, we'd rather help you make the right decision than simply sell you seedlings.

We believe that successful plantations create lasting customers.

— Looking Ahead

Black walnut teaches us something that is becoming increasingly rare. Some of the best investments we make are not measured in months or even years. They're measured in generations.

The seedling you plant today may one day provide shade for your grandchildren, habitat for wildlife, beautiful timber for a future craftsman, or simply the quiet satisfaction of knowing you improved the land entrusted to your care.

That is a remarkable thing. Thank you for spending your time with us. We wish you every success with your black walnut orchard, wherever your journey begins.

— Stay Connected

If you'd like to continue learning about growing black walnut and other high-value tree species, we'd love to stay in touch. Throughout the year we share practical growing advice, nursery updates, new research, and seasonal planting information to help Canadian landowners make the most of their trees.

You can also explore our website for additional resources, planting guides, and information about our bare-root black walnut seedlings. We hope to be part of your planting journey for many years to come.



Plant for Tomorrow

The best time to plant a tree was many years ago.

The next best time is when you've taken the time to learn how to do it well. Thank you for reading **The Canadian Black Walnut Orchard Starter Kit** — we hope it marks the beginning of something that will grow for generations.



Every mature black walnut begins with a single seedling — and someone willing to plant it.



NOVA SCOTIA
GROWN



SHIPPED ACROSS
CANADA



SEASONAL BARE-ROOT
SHIPPING



HARDY
SELECTIONS



EXPERT GROWING
GUIDANCE

LITTLE TREE FARM · WENTZELL LAKE, NOVA SCOTIA